

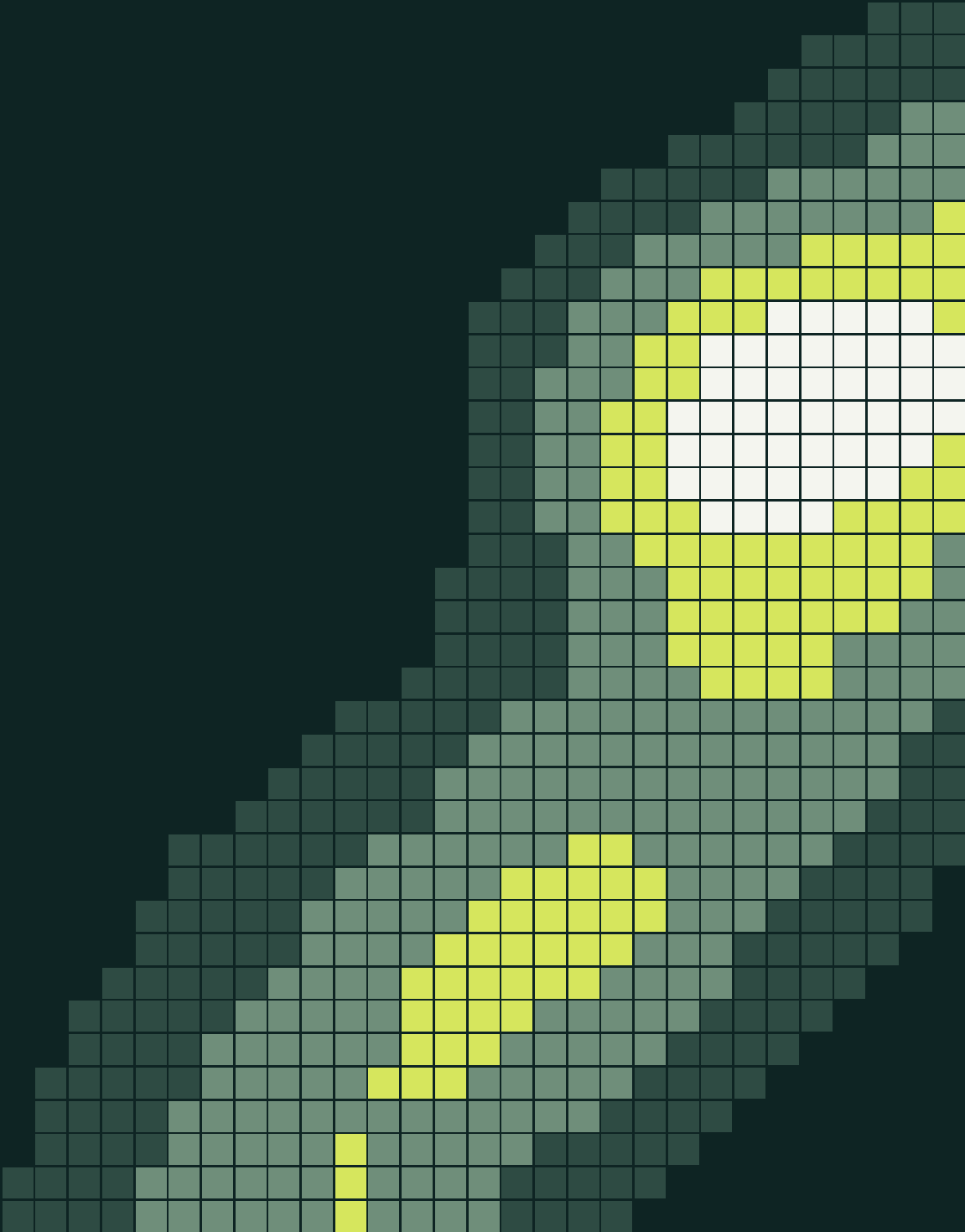
LOGO BRIEF V2 · DRAFT FOR APPROVAL

The mountain, measured.

Logo brief v2: a new symbol, palette and background system for
HCO — High Country Observations.

Draft for approval · 2 October 2026 · Supersedes the Stage 1 symbol
recommendation if approved; naming and font licensing are still open.

01-02	03	04-06	07
The ask and the references	The idea	Symbol, colour, background	This round



01 · THE ASK

Bring the mountain back — as data, not scenery.

WHAT YOU ASKED FOR

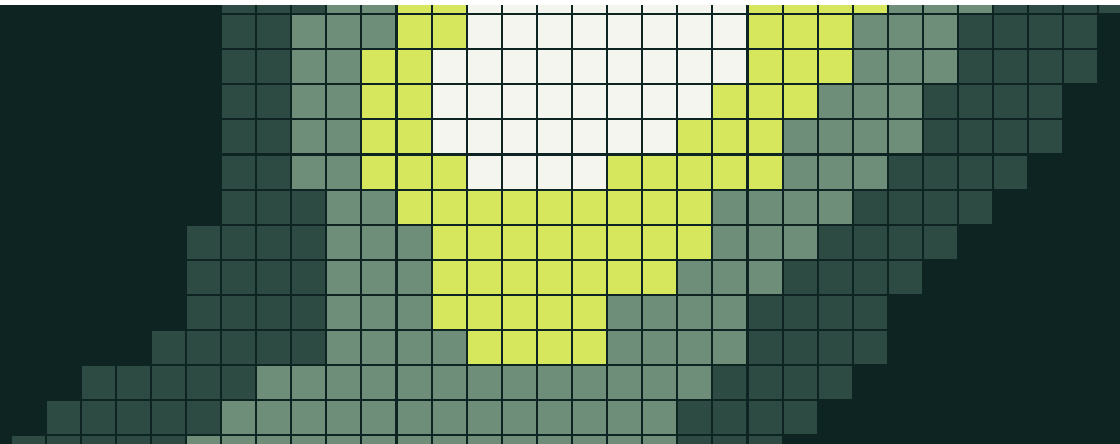
- 01 A coloured or conceptual background as part of how the identity is seen.
- 02 The colour palette carried into the logo itself.
- 03 Digitised mountains as the background image.
- 04 A minimalist, pixel-style symbol that reads as data mapped onto terrain. The mountain can come back.

WHAT STILL HOLDS

- HCO is a practical advisory business for farmers, ranchers and agricultural operators: business and operations as well as field and property intelligence. It is not a drone vendor, an outdoor label or a luxury brand.
- The mark works flat, in one colour, at 16 px and with no background behind it.
- No invented data, clients, results or locations. Terrain imagery is real and attributed, or labelled illustrative.
- Still open from Stage 1: “Group” or “Consulting”, and font licensing.

THE TENSION

The original brief warned against mountains, dramatic imagery and effects. This direction brings all three back. It works only if the mountain arrives as data rather than scenery: measured, gridded, flat and honest. If a design on this brief looks like an outdoor brand or a drone start-up once it is placed on terrain, it has failed.



02 · READING THE REFERENCES

HCO Identity Study 01



TAKE

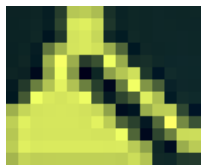
- One bright data colour on a deep field: strong figure and ground, and a clean break from green and gold.
- Terrain as atmosphere behind a flat mark.
- The honest caption: “Illustrative terrain study”.

LEAVE

- A pixelated peak beside initials is still the category's most common mark, now in 8-bit.
- Mixed step sizes break the grid's own logic.
- At 16 px a module is 0.8 px: the ridge and channel blur into one shape (test, left).
- The photoreal render is dramatic and dark, closer to adventure or tech than to advice.
- “Drone mapping & field intelligence” describes half the business.
- The wordmark is an unaltered neutral grotesk.

MEASURED

- Symbol lime #D6E65D on a deep field #0C2425; wordmark #F5F6EE.
- Symbol $\approx 20 \times 16$ modules (a 16.5 px module at 1920 px wide).
- Left flank steps two modules wide; right flank one module.
- A one-module outer ridge, separated by a stepped channel.

16 PX, ENLARGED $\times 8$ 

02 · READING THE REFERENCES

Four more, and what they agree on

Brace (logosystem.co/logo/brace) could not be opened: the site is blocked from this environment. Paste a screenshot and it will be added to this analysis.



MetaLine

- One notch detail, repeated with discipline, gives a simple shape a signature.
- Slanted speed strokes and gradient backgrounds: logistics and fintech shorthand.



Stepped bars

- Maximum economy: two shapes and one step, legible at any size. The step reads as a terrain section and as a change in data.
- Alone it has little to own, and it sits close to the earlier Rise route.



requiem

- A letter built from the symbol's own modules, so mark and name share one geometry. A saturated field with fine grain, while the logo stays flat.
- The arc vocabulary, and grain inside the logo.



Pixel ring

- The fewest cells that still make a form: eight. Generous cells stay legible. And it is an O — HCO's own letter.
- Anything that tips into 8-bit game nostalgia: small cells, many cells, sprite-like figures.

01 · ONE MODULE

Every cell the same size. No half-cells, rounding or mixed steps.

02 · FEW CELLS

The strongest references use 8-20 cells. The weakest move is detail.

03 · FLAT MARK, RICH FIELD

Colour and texture live in the background. The mark stays flat.

04 · ONE SIGNATURE

A notch, a step or one flagged cell — never several.

03 · THE IDEA

The mountain, measured.

A mountain isn't drawn; it's sampled. Drone surveys and elevation models turn land into a grid of measured cells — rasters of height, crop health and change. HCO's work makes the same move: a great deal of observation, reduced to the few cells that matter.

The symbol is the high country at the coarsest honest resolution: terrain sampled into a handful of cells, with colour encoding value. The background is the same terrain at full resolution. Logo and background are one dataset at two scales — the observation, and the judgement.

KEY FINDING

Sample from above, not from the side. Side-on, any mountain sampled to eight columns becomes a ziggurat (the silhouette) or a bar chart (a single section). Sampled from above, the way a drone sees it, the same terrain becomes a diagonal of cells with one summit: specific, asymmetric and much harder to mistake for a stock peak.

SIDE VIEW

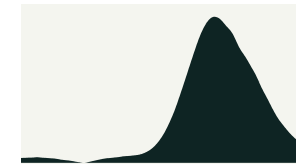


SILHOUETTE



8 COLUMNS

Ziggurat



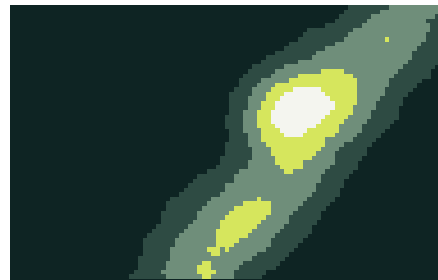
ONE SECTION



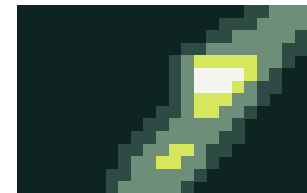
8 COLUMNS

Bar chart

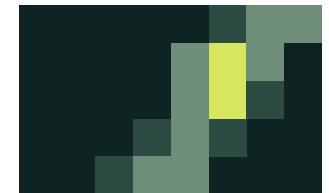
PLAN VIEW · THE WAY A DRONE SEES IT



96 × 60 CELLS · THE BACKGROUND



24 × 15 CELLS



8 × 5 CELLS · THE SCALE OF A SYMBOL

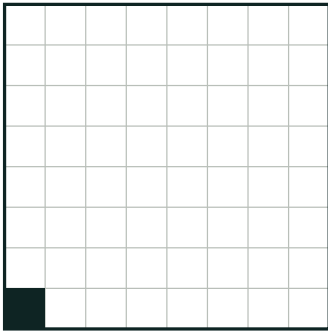
PRINCIPLE DIAGRAMS FROM ONE PROCEDURAL TERRAIN — ILLUSTRATIVE, NOT REAL ELEVATION DATA AND NOT LOGO PROPOSALS

04 · REQUIREMENTS

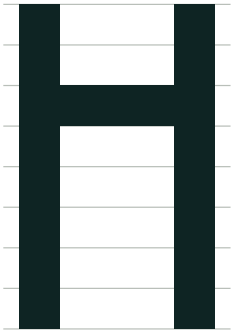
Symbol and wordmark

SYMBOL	
GRID	One square module. The symbol grid is no larger than 8 × 8, so a module is at least 2 px when the symbol is 16 px.
CELLS	8–24 filled cells. No half-cells, rounded corners, outlines, gradients or effects inside the mark.
SOURCE	Sampled from terrain, preferably top-down. Asymmetric and specific — never a symmetrical stepped triangle.
COLOUR	Up to four ramp values, always in the same order (low → high), plus at most one Flag cell for the observation.
ONE COLOUR	Must also work with every cell in one colour, in Basalt and in Chalk.
MUST NOT RESEMBLE	A ziggurat or pyramid, a game sprite or block game, a bar chart or growth staircase, a QR code, four-pane window tiles, a chequered flag or a crosshair.
SMALL SIZES	Tested at 16, 24 and 32 px. A simplified 16 px cut is allowed only if it keeps the same idea.

WORDMARK	
NAME	HCO, with “High Country Observations” as the expanded name; “Consulting” optional until naming is confirmed.
MEASURE	Wordmark stem width = one symbol module; symbol height = cap height or a whole number of modules.
W1 · HIGH BAR	Carry the raised crossbar onto the grid: it fills the sixth of eight rows (centre at 68.75%, close to Stage 1's 71.5%).
W2 · GRID-BUILT	HCO drawn on the symbol's module with straight stems and squared counters — readable, and never a pixel font.
NOT	An unaltered neutral grotesk (Study 01), or any bitmap or pixel typeface.



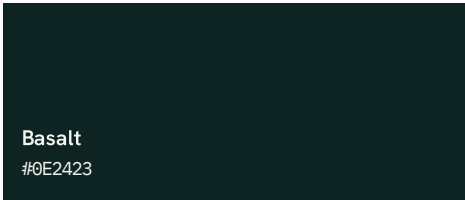
8 × 8 maximum. One filled module shown.
At 16 px: 16 ÷ 8 = 2 px per module.



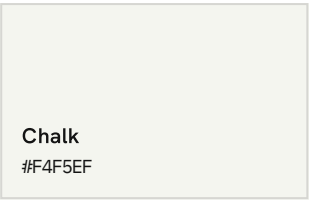
W1: crossbar in row 6 of 8;
stem = one module.

05 · COLOUR

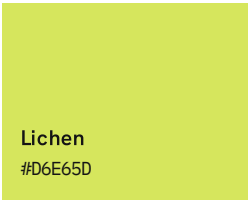
The palette is a data ramp



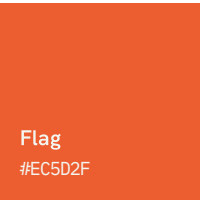
The field. Dominant, about 60%. Developed from Study 01's #0C2425, slightly more mineral.



Type and light ground, about 25%. A crisp neutral, not cream.



The signal: the highest value in every ramp, about 10%. Inherited from Study 01.



The observation: one cell, one marker, one call-out. Under 3%. Survey flagging-tape orange.

THE RAMP: LOW → HIGH, IN THE LOGO, THE MAPS AND THE REPORTS



RULES

- The full-colour symbol sits on Basalt. On Chalk, use the one-colour Basalt symbol: Lichen on Chalk measures 1.25:1.
- The ramp order never changes: Moss → Sage → Lichen → Chalk means low → high. The same ramp colours HCO's maps and reports, so the logo teaches people to read the data.
- Flag never decorates. It marks something someone should look at.
- No gradients, and no green and gold.

MEASURED CONTRAST (WCAG)

	on		Chalk / Basalt	14.79:1	Text (AA)
	on		Lichen / Basalt	11.84:1	Text (AA)
	on		Flag / Basalt	4.77:1	Text (AA)
	on		Sage / Basalt	4.5:1	Text (AA)
	on		Moss / Basalt	1.7:1	Not for text or marks
	on		Flag / Chalk	3.1:1	Large text, graphics
	on		Sage / Chalk	3.29:1	Large text, graphics
	on		Lichen / Chalk	1.25:1	Not for text or marks

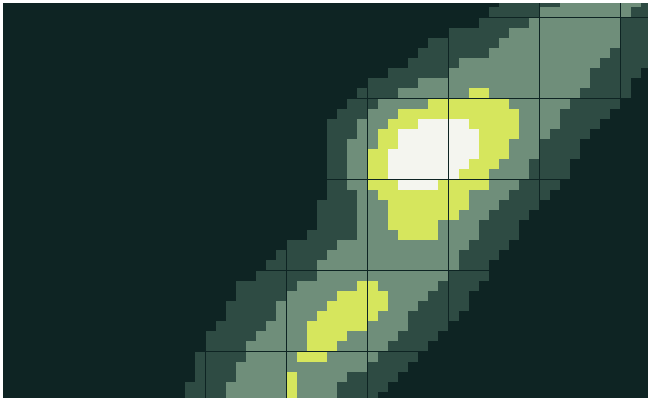
TREND RISK

Lime on near-black has been a tech and fintech staple since 2024. It photographs well but dates quickly; test a more mineral alternative before locking Lichen.

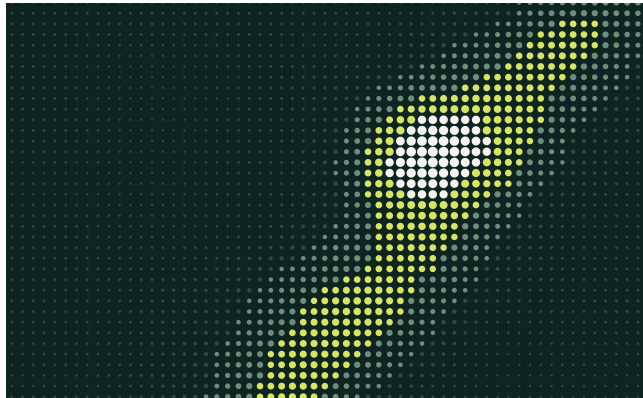
STARTING HYPOTHESES FOR TESTING — HEX AND RGB ONLY. NO PANTONE OR CMYK UNTIL A PRINT PROFILE IS AGREED.

06 · BACKGROUND

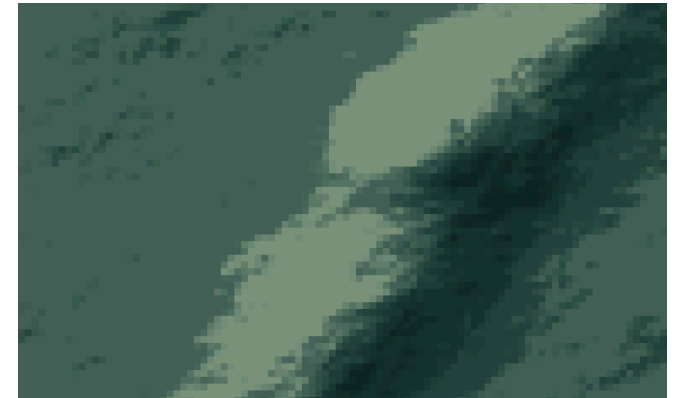
Digitised mountains: three render modes, one dataset

**A · Pixel heightmap**

Cells coloured by the ramp: the symbol at full resolution.

**B · Dot matrix**

Dot size encodes elevation; a halftone that stays quiet behind type.

**C · Quantised hillshade**

Relief posterised into five tones of the field colour; the quietest option.

DATA

Use real elevation data — Copernicus DEM GLO-30 (free, attribution required) or USGS 3DEP (public domain) — from a region the client confirms. Until then, use procedural terrain labelled “Illustrative terrain study”. No place names, coordinates or scale bars unless they are real and confirmed.

RULES

- The background never carries the logo's meaning; the logo must stand without it.
- Keep a quiet zone behind the logo, inside its clear space.
- Text over terrain measures at least 4.5:1 against the busiest area beneath it.
- Show terrain at a legible data resolution: no blur, glow, depth of field or cinematic lighting.

AVOID

Photoreal dramatic renders · neon wireframes and HUD overlays · contour wallpaper · stacked ridgelines (the “Unknown Pleasures” cover) · crosshairs and random coordinates · fake data labels.

07 · THIS ROUND

What comes back, and how it's judged

DELIVERABLES

THREE SYMBOL STUDIES	S1 Plan raster: terrain from above, $\leq 8 \times 8$, ramp-coloured. S2 Plan raster with one Flag cell. S3 the best side-view sample, tested against the ziggurat and bar-chart traps. Each in full colour on Basalt, one colour in Basalt and Chalk, reversed, at 16/24/32 px, with its construction grid.
TWO WORDMARKS	W1 High Bar on the grid; W2 grid-built.
PALETTE	Final values with a measured contrast table.
BACKGROUND	Two render modes, on illustrative or confirmed elevation data.
PRESENTATION	Three identity studies in the Study 01 format (logo on terrain), plus every logo flat on Chalk with no background.
RECOMMENDATION	An evaluation, and one recommended route.

HOW WE'LL JUDGE IT

- Reads as terrain or data within five seconds — not a game, a pyramid, a chart or a staircase.
- Holds at 16 px, with a module of at least 2 px.
- Works in one colour and with no background.
- Looks like an advisory practice for farms and ranches, not a drone vendor or an outdoor brand.
- Uses the palette as a data ramp, consistently.
- Passes a recorded resemblance check against existing pixel-mountain and pixel-grid marks (not trademark clearance).

OPEN QUESTIONS

- 01 Brace: please paste a screenshot; the link is blocked here.
- 02 Study 01: who produced it, and are its lime and deep green the intended starting palette?
- 03 Terrain: real elevation data from a region you confirm, or illustrative?
- 04 Wordmark: keep High Bar, or rebuild on the grid?
- 05 Descriptor: Study 01's "Drone mapping & field intelligence" covers half the business. Use the two service areas instead?
- 06 Still open: "Group" or "Consulting", and font licensing.